

Module 3 - Data Limitations Reflection

One of the biggest limitations I noticed with using Grad Cafe data is that the information only represents the people who actually chose to submit their results. It does not represent every person who applied to graduate school. Because the information is anonymous and self-reported, there is really no way to know if certain groups are more likely to post than others. For example, someone who was extremely excited about being accepted or very disappointed about being rejected may be more likely to share their experience. In my analysis, 37.11% of the Fall 2026 entries were acceptances. That number tells me what percentage of the Fall 2026 entries in my database were accepted, but it does not mean that 37.11% is the actual graduate-school acceptance rate. The data is useful for looking at patterns, but I would be careful about using it to make conclusions about all graduate-school applicants because the people represented on Grad Café are only a portion of the overall applicant population.

Another issue I saw firsthand was the quality and consistency of the information being submitted. Some applicants did not provide every piece of information, while other entries contained values that were clearly unusual. For example, my database produced an average GRE Quantitative score of 262.89 and an average GRE Analytical Writing score of 8.34. Those results immediately stood out because they show how inaccurate or inconsistently entered information can affect an average. I also saw why university and program names had to be matched carefully because the same school or program could be entered several different ways, such as using an abbreviation instead of the full name. This assignment helped me see the difference between what a database can mathematically calculate and what those numbers actually mean. The calculations may be correct based on the information in the database, but that does not automatically mean the underlying data is complete, accurate, or representative of the real-world population.